

Democratic odds rise in House and Senate

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-10-08 00:48

【メール原文】

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7 Oct 2026 11:45 EDT Discover more on the Portal

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Polling gains boost Democratic odds in both chambers of Congress. We are upgrading our odds of a Democratic victory in the House to 90% (from 85%) and in the Senate to 60% (from 55%) on the back of a continued polling surge. Democrats have widened their generic ballot lead to 9 points, and polling leads in key Senate races have remained durable with just weeks until the election.

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We also now expect a larger Democratic majority in the House; using 2026 district boundaries and assuming a uniform 10.5-point national swing from 2024, we expect at least 20 districts to flip toward Democrats (40% odds, up from 10%). A larger majority is good news for Democrats across the board, as it will ease the process of electing a speaker and render the Democratic majority more resilient to a potential shift back toward Republicans in 2028.

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Democrats' Senate outlook is also improving as pickup opportunities expand. They hold leads of over a point in five Republican-held states, enough to win a 52-seat majority if they win all their own states, and their success in expanding the map guards against a potential loss in a blue state like Minnesota.

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Republicans are receiving a massive influx of cash at this point in the cycle, but there is scant evidence that spending will sway likely voters. The national environment is so strongly negative that we doubt advertising will meaningfully shift races at this stage.

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For more, please see Polling gains boost Democratic odds in House and Senate , 6 October 2026.

Gas tax action will occur in states, not Congress. President Trump floated the idea of suspending the federal gas and diesel tax yesterday, but with that plan unlikely to come to fruition, action on price relief via tax suspensions will be a state-driven affair.

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The impediments to a suspension of the federal gas tax are high. Such a move would require an act of Congress, which is out of session until after the midterms; the president cannot remove the tax unilaterally, using emergency powers. Congress hasn't moved on any of the three bills introduced that would suspend the tax, and Trump's call isn't likely to move the needle, especially before the midterms.

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A suspension of the tax would cause problems for the Highway Trust Fund, for which the gas tax is the primary funding source. The fund is already scheduled to run dry sometime in 2028, and suspending the tax—at a monthly cost estimated by the Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget at \$3.5 billion—for three months would move the date at which the fund runs dry by three or four months, accelerating the timeline on one of Congress's major tasks next year.

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In the absence of federal action, states will drive immediate price relief via tax suspensions. Three states have enacted full suspensions; three others have issued either partial suspensions or delays on planned increases. If more movement comes, it is more likely to be in Republican states—in a last-ditch effort to boost Republican candidates ahead of the midterms—than in Democratic-governed ones, which have mostly been cooler to the idea of tax suspensions.

Talks over US-China nuclear inspections are in early stages. The US and China have reportedly begun preliminary talks to establish reciprocal nuclear site visits after Chinese officials floated the idea in meetings with their US counterparts earlier this year.

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President Trump has had an interest in nuclear issues across both of his terms in the White House, and recently voiced his support for trilateral nuclear arms control talks with Russia and China during Chinese President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington. However, many policymakers will view China's offer skeptically, questioning both whether talks will materialize into an agreement and the political intent of the offer itself.

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China's offer plays into the positive tone of recent bilateral relations and signals a willingness to cooperate in an area of mutual strategic interest at a time of heightened geopolitical risk. Given China's staunch position that it will not accept any measures that would slow its nuclear buildout, it remains to be seen whether any substantial agreement is on the table.

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Nuclear site visits primarily serve as confidence-building measures and have long been a part of US arms control policy. While the prospects of a reciprocal visit agreement remain unclear, increased transparency on nuclear issues can help reduce the risk of miscalculation in the future and set the stage for further arms control negotiations.

Quote of the Day

"I don't think President Trump is going to come to Maine ... I've heard nothing from his office, and I'm not exactly his favorite Senator." – Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) in the first of her four debates against

Democrat Troy Jackson last night. Collins's hopes of victory in the tossup race depend on her ability to convince a large share of voters that it is worth sticking with her distinct brand of bipartisan cooperation rather than electing a Democratic senator. Part of that strategy relies on keeping her distance from the White House. Trump appears quite willing to go along with that strategy, with his upcoming campaign appearances all scheduled in deep-red states, along with Ohio.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Kendal Walker

Senior Analyst, United States

walker@eurasiagroup.net

Jason Walter

Researcher, United States

walter@eurasiagroup.net

EG US Daily

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

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